

JULY

EUROPE

Rapujuhlat, Finland

From late July for the next two months, Finland is simply smitten with the crayfish. Festivals and parties involve special plates, table linen, cutlery, bibs, lanterns, and even songs – and mounds of crayfish, of course. The feast is best enjoyed outdoors on a long summer evening, during which noisy, messy eating is actively encouraged.

Whitstable Oyster Festival, Kent, UK

Every aspect of Whitstable shouts tradition, and none more so than the oysters at the center of this exciting week-long festival. Entertainment abounds, with shanty singers, crab-catching, kite-flying, seashore safaris, and a very muddy tug-of-war. Don't miss the oyster-eating competition and the masked parade finale. www.whitstableoysterfestival.com

Pichelsteinerfest, Regen, Germany

This colorful festival is an encounter with all things Bavarian. Celebrating the delicious *Pichelsteiner* (a local stew of beef, pork, lamb, and vegetables in gravy), the whole town enjoys six days of marching bands, flag parades, music, dancing, giant fountains, fireworks, and lantern-lit boats on the Regen River.

Fête des Fruits Rouges, Noyon, France

Noyon's soft fruit has been renowned for 1,000 years and, for one day every July, the lovely cathedral square is filled with a mouthwatering aroma, as market stands are loaded with ripe, juicy currants, berries, and cherries. After a blessing of the harvest, the festivities begin, with cooking demonstrations and tastings, medieval games, and a huge communal feast.

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Knysna Oyster Festival, South Africa

They call it “the 10 best days of your winter” and, if you love oysters, they're probably right. Not even the South African Navy can stay away, sailing their huge minesweepers into Knysna's beautiful bay for the event. There are countless oyster stylings to sample, perfect with local microbrewery Mitchell's Raven Stout. www.oysterfestival.co.za

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Singapore Food Festival

It's all about the delicious diversity of local cuisine at this month-long festival, which sees events all around the island, from tasting cruises and hands-on masterclasses to the lively Singapore River market. Best of all, Clarke Quay is transformed into Food Street, where street food and fine dining come together. <http://singaporefoodfestival.com.sg>

NORTH AMERICA

National Cherry Festival, Traverse City, Michigan, USA

For eight packed days in the heart of “Cherry Country” on the shores of Grand Traverse Bay, over half a million cherry-lovers

gather for pie-eating, pit-spitting, road-racing, beach volleyball, and even Cherryopolis contests. And, if you can win the hole-in-one competition, the real cherry is the million-dollar prize! <http://visit.cherryfestival.org>

Copper River Wild! Salmon Festival, Cordova, Alaska, USA

Copper River salmon are prized the world over as simply the best you can eat. The unique flavor comes from extra oils they need to survive the freezing glacial waters of their spawning grounds. So it's worth the effort to seek out remote Cordova in Prince William Sound and join in the festivities with music, art fairs, road races, and plenty of tasty salmon.

Bagelfest, Mattoon, Illinois, USA

Americans love bagels so much that they have two national bagel days. The best way to celebrate this scrumptious twice-cooked Polish bread is in Mattoon, Illinois, where they bake a billion bagels a year. A giant Bagel Parade opens the festival, with a street market, pageants, dancing, a rock concert, and, best of all, free bagels. www.mattoonbagelfest.com

AUGUST

EUROPE

La Tomatina, Buñol, Spain

This is probably the most famous food festival of them all, and yet it's not about eating so much as painting the town red with tomatoes – around 100 tons of them. The battle only lasts an hour, but by the end, the 30,000 or so participants are soaked in scarlet juice and slipping and squelching in a sea of tomato pulp. www.tomatina.net

Isle of Wight Garlic Festival, Newchurch, UK

England's largest island, on the south coast, is perhaps more famous for its music festival held every June, but its annual celebration of “the stinking rose” draws equally enthusiastic crowds for garlic beer, garlic ice cream, and other fragrant delicacies. Non-garlic produce is also showcased. “Best of British” entertainment is on hand and visitors can be sure of a nice cup of (non-garlic) tea. www.garlic-festival.co.uk



La Pourcailhade, Trie-sur-Baïse, France

Trie-sur-Baïse is in France's prime pork-producing region, so it should be no surprise that there is a Brotherhood of the Pig here. Competitions at their annual Pig Festival include piglet races, sausage-eating, best pig outfit, and the National Pig Squealing Competition (for people, not pigs). There is also music and dancing in the evening. www.pourcailhade.com

Skala Kalloni Sardine Festival, Lesvos, Greece

The stunning Gulf of Kalloni is almost an inland sea, and is famed for the quality of its sardines. The fishing port of Skala Kalloni gives thanks for its catch one weekend of the year with a feast of barbecued sardines and ouzo, along with traditional Greek music and dancing. It's an utterly charming experience.

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Imouzzer Honey Festival, Morocco

Jimi Hendrix reputedly named the “Paradise Valley” where Imouzzer sits, in the foothills of the Atlas Mountains. Here the Berbers keep bees in hives made of reeds and clay, and harvest exquisite honey flavored with mountain herbs and flowers. The Honey Festival celebrates this taste of paradise.

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Yugambah Corroboree, Southport, Queensland, Australia

What could be more Australian than a bush tucker feast after a walkabout? OK, the four-day Drumley Walk is optional, but the Yugambah Corroboree Festival welcomes the walkers with traditional bush food, Aboriginal songs, arts and crafts exhibitions, and plenty of activities for jarjums (kids). *Yau yilnanbaugull* – or “yes, please!” www.thedrumleywalk.com

Onam, Kerala, India

For Kerala's Malayali people, and for this lovely state as a whole, the ten-day harvest festival of Onam is the most

